

Chapter 3 - Sect Master

The current Chu Qingqiu seemed somewhat different from usual. There was something in her eyes that Ning Fuyi couldn't understand, as if the purest deity had been possessed by demonic energy—both mad and desperate.

"You don't know," she said quietly.

Ning Fuyi was stunned by her words. When she came to her senses again, the person before her had already disappeared, taking Qiu Yi with her, leaving only a pile of thin garments on the ground.

She was gone. Ning Fuyi breathed a sigh of relief, then suddenly realized something and began struggling furiously.

"At least untie me first!" she shouted angrily. "Chu Qingqiu!!!"

After calling for a long while with no response, Ning Fuyi could only spit in frustration and try to use what little immortal power remained in her body to untie the ropes. However, despite breaking out in a sweat, the ropes seemed iron-forged and wouldn't budge.

When she recovered her demonic power, she would definitely pay her back in kind, Ning Fuyi thought viciously.

Just as she was frowning in distress, she suddenly heard footsteps outside the door. Ning Fuyi immediately became alert. But before she could shout "Who's there?", her heartbeat stopped for an instant and she lost her words.

She saw a beauty skip in from outside—truly a lotus face with a willow waist. A blue silk scarf covered her lips, and her gentle eyes were like clear lakes filled with water. As soon as she saw Ning Fuyi, she wiped away tears and sobbed silently.

Ning Fuyi was completely stunned.

The beauty before her was no different from hundreds of years ago, even wearing the same water-blue silk dress she had loved most. The lotus wood carving around her waist was a birthday gift from Ning Fuyi, now intact and unburned to ash.

The beauty had never turned to ash either.

"Wenzhu," Ning Fuyi murmured. She seemed to relive that great fire, her eyes stinging from the smoke.

Wenzhu, Liu Wenzhu. The treasured daughter of the Liu family, the greatest immortal cultivation clan, and her childhood friend who had grown up together. Born to luxury and gentle as soft jade and delicate flowers, yet due to villainous schemes, she had left behind only a few words before leaping into the endless hellfire on her behalf.

"Yiyi, live well," she had said.

"Yiyi!" The image from memory was suddenly replaced by the living person before her. Ning Fuyi's body trembled as she pulled herself from the recollection, looking down at the woman untying her bonds.

Though she had long guessed she would see her dear friend again, actually seeing her still brought a tremendous emotional impact.

"Good thing you're awake. You were covered in blood just now—I thought you..." Liu Wenzhu's movements were gentle yet efficient, quickly using immortal power to untie the ropes. Her eyes were red with concern. "Look, you're still wet and dressed so lightly. Divine Venerable Chu agreed to treat you—why would she tie you to this stone pillar?"

"You made the Divine Venerable angry again, didn't you? Though Divine Venerable is strict, her heart is good. I don't know why you always clash with her like this." Liu Wenzhu helped Ning Fuyi up, handing her the robes Chu Qingqiu had left behind.

"Her?" Ning Fuyi scoffed.

"Yes. Today no one in the sect could save you. I nearly took you to the Liu family to ask Father for help. Fortunately, we encountered Divine Venerable Chu at the foot of the mountain—only then were you saved. Really, you shouldn't be so willful." Liu Wenzhu gently scolded.

Though Ning Fuyi disagreed in her heart, she didn't argue back. She hid in a corner to change clothes. The garments Chu Qingqiu left behind were as conservative and proper as their owner—after putting them on, not even a glimpse of neck was visible.

Ning Fuyi tugged at the collar in annoyance.

When she emerged, she was dressed in goose-yellow robes with her disheveled hair loosely bound behind her. Apart from the weary expression on her face from recent injury, she looked exactly like a clean and pretty young girl of fifteen or sixteen.

Though she didn't know why Chu Qingqiu had chosen to save her in this life, there were pressing matters at hand, and she didn't have the energy to ponder Chu Qingqiu's motivations.

"Wenzhu, what time is it now? Are the others all in Cloud Deep Hall?" she asked.

Liu Wenzhu was surprised by her composure. After hesitating a moment, she nodded: "Yes. Master Uncle Mei Chengshou somehow learned of the Sect Master's incident and immediately sealed the mountain gate, summoning all elders and disciples to Cloud Deep Hall. I was worried about your condition, so I didn't go. They've been meeting behind closed doors—the sect feels empty, with no news coming out."

Ning Fuyi nodded, restraining her usual frivolous demeanor, her eyes dark.

Mother's death was already set in stone, but other matters weren't too late—Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate hadn't been taken by others, and her family and friends hadn't yet died tragically.

In her previous life, though she had survived, she fell seriously ill. By the time she awakened, the entire Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had changed hands. The new sect master was that Mei Chengshou, her mother's former junior brother—a man of poor cultivation and truly a treacherous, lazy, greedy, and slippery character.

Since he took office, she and the sect disciples no longer had protection. One of the strongest immortal cultivation sects, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, declined from then on, leading to all the subsequent disasters.

Liu Wenzhu looked at Ning Fuyi in surprise. She knew her friend's temperament well—though she appeared carefree and unrestrained, her thoughts were most delicate. Now that the Condensing Heaven Sect Master had met with misfortune, Ning Fuyi was actually this calm.

Though she had doubts, she didn't ask more, thinking Ning Fuyi was forcing herself to be strong. Her heart ached even more as she reached out to grasp her fingers.

"Yiyi, if you want to cry, go ahead and cry. I'll keep you company," she said softly.

Ning Fuyi knew she was worried, so she smiled and squeezed her hand back.

Mother had been dead for hundreds of years. Though she still felt sorrow when remembering, this grief had been washed away and blurred by the passing years. Even pretending deep sorrow would be difficult.

"I don't want to cry." Ning Fuyi shook her head, looking toward the sliver of brilliant sunlight leaking from outside the cave. "I just want to live properly again."

Since heaven had given her a chance to be reborn, she didn't want to repeat past mistakes. Even if she could protect just one more person, she wouldn't have to watch them die in heartbreak again.

Ning Fuyi looked around and spotted the white ropes on the ground. With a thought, she picked them up and tucked them into her sleeves.

"Wenzhu, take me to Cloud Deep Hall," she said.

Cloud Deep Hall lived up to its name, situated where the mountain clouds were thickest. Looking down revealed rolling dense clouds crashing against the cliffs like waves, reaching dozens of zhang² high. Outside the hall stood forty-nine stone lions in rows, winding into a path leading to the hall's interior.

She hadn't been to this place for hundreds of years. As Ning Fuyi walked past the stone lions with Liu Wenzhu, she felt somewhat dazed by the passage of time.

"Who goes there!" A stern shout suddenly rang out. Liu Wenzhu instinctively stepped in front of Ning Fuyi, her eyebrows slightly furrowed as she glared at two unfamiliar men guarding the hall entrance.

"I'm a sect disciple. All the sect's disciples are inside—can't we enter?" Liu Wenzhu held up the glazed plaque symbolizing Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, speaking gently.

The two men looked down at them condescendingly, their gazes settling on Ning Fuyi's face with a hint of surprise.

"The Immortal Venerable has ordered that after the meeting begins, no one else may enter. You two should return and wait for the meeting to end," one of the men said dismissively, waving his hand.

Liu Wenzhu was also angered by this, stepping forward to speak, but was held back by Ning Fuyi tugging at her sleeve.

"What if we insist on entering?" Ning Fuyi asked lightly. She smiled again, tilting her head slightly—that look made even Liu Wenzhu shiver.

As if laced with the most deadly poison, completely at odds with the young girl's face.

The two men were also stunned for a moment, then looked at each other and burst into mocking laughter. One of them laughed while walking down the steps, looking the young girl up and down, reaching out toward her shoulder.

"This little girl has quite the nerve. Doesn't she know who we—"

Halfway through his words, something suddenly shot out from the girl's sleeve, crawling up his arm like a snake. The man cried out in alarm, his face changing color as he retreated repeatedly. However, that thing was much faster than him. In the blink of an eye, both men were tightly bound together, back to back, crashing to the ground.

"How dare you! What demon magic is this! Release us immediately!" The man shouted furiously at Ning Fuyi. But as soon as he finished speaking, Ning Fuyi pulled out a piece of cloth from her bosom, tore it in half with a ripping sound, and stuffed both pieces into their mouths.

"So noisy," she said, clapping her hands.

"This is Divine Venerable Chu's magical artifact³. Even if you have heaven-reaching cultivation, you can't untie it yourselves." Ning Fuyi crouched down with a smile, extending her finger. She breathed on it and flicked the man's forehead hard, watching with satisfaction as his eyes filled with bloodshot fury.

Fortunately, she remembered to take Chu Qingqiu's Flying Feather Rope⁴, and fortunately Chu Qingqiu hadn't recalled it yet. Ning Fuyi was satisfied as she stood up, pulling the still-shocked Liu Wenzhu along as she strode into the hall.

The hall was bathed in sunlight, no different from outside, with no visible ceiling when looking up.

First to catch the eye were hundreds upon hundreds of sect disciples, standing in black masses filling every gap in the great hall. Deep inside was a high platform with two people standing on it. One wore black and gold robes with prominently protruding brow bones, his eyes almost buried under thick eyebrows, his hair and beard mixed black and white—this was Mei Chengshou, who had just entered the Great Vehicle Realm⁵ this year.

The other person Ning Fuyi was more familiar with—the Chief Elder of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, an elderly man with a grizzled beard and hunched body, responsible for managing the sect's most important treasures. He usually stayed in seclusion and was rarely seen.

At this moment, he was tremblingly holding up a huge black Foundation Stone⁶, muttering something. Ancient characters flowed across the stone like flowing light, incomprehensible to observers.

The succession ceremony!

Seeing that Mei Chengshou's palm was about to cover the stone, Ning Fuyi's heart tightened, and she immediately shouted loudly: "Elder, wait!"

Fortunately, though the Chief Elder looked like he might ascend to immortality at any moment, his hearing was remarkably good. He immediately turned and took away the Foundation Stone. Mei Chengshou, eager to press his hand down, nearly stumbled and fell.

Several suppressed chuckles came from among the disciples.

"Who dares make such noise!" Mei Chengshou steadied himself and roared angrily. When he saw Ning Fuyi, his brows knotted like a death knot.

"Master Uncle Mei, it's been a long time." Ning Fuyi smiled without warmth, pulling at the corners of her mouth, then strode toward the high platform. When the disciples saw her, they all became agitated, whispering among themselves.

"Didn't they say she was dying? How is she fine now?"

"The Sect Master passed away, yet she shows no grief at all—truly strange."

Ning Fuyi heard all these idle comments but paid them no mind. Instead, she met Mei Chengshou's suffocating gaze and stood firmly below the high platform, looking up.

"Ning Fuyi?" Mei Chengshou almost squeezed these words through his teeth, then smiled.

"Barging into Cloud Deep Hall, disrupting the succession ceremony—is this how your mother taught you?"

"Master Uncle worries too much. My mother never taught me anything." Ning Fuyi smiled with narrowed eyes, lifting her skirt hem as she brazenly stepped onto the high platform. "Rather, Master Uncle, as a dignified Great Vehicle Immortal Venerable, you always like using underhanded methods. How disappointing to my mother's teachings."

Mei Chengshou's mockery was deflected by Ning Fuyi's thick skin, his face turning alternately green and pale: "Throughout history, sect masters have only been recognized by the Foundation Stone's acknowledgment before succession. Don't speak nonsense! Someone—"

"Though the Foundation Stone has the Foundation Spirit⁷, it's not beyond human interference." Ning Fuyi interrupted his words unhurriedly. Though her voice wasn't loud, the high platform had an amplifying effect, allowing the hundreds of disciples below to hear clearly.

As soon as these words were spoken, the platform below became even more chaotic, with disciples whispering among themselves.

"Fuyi." A purple-robed female elder below frowned in warning. "Usually causing trouble is one thing, but how can you speak such nonsense today?"

Mei Chengshou clenched his rough palms, his face alternating between green and white, glaring deadly at Ning Fuyi as he rebuked sternly: "Nonsense!"

"Whether I'm speaking nonsense, a test will tell." Ning Fuyi ignored them, walking toward the Foundation Stone and raising her hand to place her palm on it.

How could Mei Chengshou let his scheme be exposed? He immediately shouted sternly and raised his hand, sending a blast of fierce fire straight at Ning Fuyi, trying to interrupt her action.

Though his attack was meant as punishment rather than to take her life, if it hit, the injury wouldn't be light.

Ning Fuyi quickly turned to dodge. At the critical moment, a cold wind suddenly swept around her, and the red flames were instantly drowned in the wind before they could touch her clothing, disappearing without a trace.

The wind brushed across her face, gentle as a woman's delicate hand.

At the same time, the great doors burst open with a thunderous sound. Flying feathers seemed to sweep through the hall, bringing a cold fragrance. All the disciples gasped in unison, looking toward the hall entrance.

"Heavens, it's Divine Venerable Chu Ling, Chu Qingqiu!"

Footnotes:

¹ **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - The main ceremonial hall of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, located at the highest and most cloud-covered part of the mountain.

² **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters or 10.8 feet.

³ **Magical Artifact (法器)** - In cultivation fiction, these are supernatural tools imbued with spiritual power that assist cultivators in combat and daily practice.

⁴ **Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索)** - Chu Qingqiu's signature weapon/tool that can transform into binding ropes and is controlled by her spiritual power.

⁵ **Great Vehicle Realm (大乘)** - One of the highest cultivation realms in this story's power system, indicating someone of tremendous spiritual power.

⁶ **Foundation Stone (开山石)** - A sacred stone containing the spiritual essence of the sect's founder, used to validate the legitimacy of new sect leaders through spiritual recognition.

⁷ **Foundation Spirit (开山之灵)** - The spiritual consciousness dwelling within the Foundation Stone that can judge the worthiness of potential sect leaders.